

The Sin Unto Death, the Foundation of Christ, and the Body That Must Not Be Divided

John Tests the New Birth by Light, Fellowship, and Love

Why don't you open to a couple of places: First John again, and then the third chapter of First Corinthians. Hallelujah.

In First John, let us pick on this for a minute. We will skim through it again, passing in review. Put a marker in First Corinthians, because we will be over there.

The issue in this book is that if you are born again, somewhere down the line it has to show up. There are some very difficult verses in this book, and it seemed like the one thing I needed to wait on was knowing God more in the nature of His love. Not that He did not love me, but the more His love developed in me, the more I could look at Him and understand how He works.

John walked in a lot of that. Sometimes in his writings he just writes past us. He makes statements that people of grace, especially eternal-security people, hate. He says, "He that sins is of the devil," with no explanation or anything.

This is why he says things the way he does in this book, and it is also because of the doctrinal war he had engaged himself in.

How about kicking in at verse 3:

That which we have seen and heard declare we unto you,
that ye also may have fellowship with us:
and truly our fellowship is with the Father,
and with his Son Jesus Christ.
And these things write we unto you,
that your joy may be full.
This then is the message which we have heard of him,
and declare unto you,
that God is light,
and in him is no darkness at all.

Then verse 6:

If we say that we have fellowship with him,
and walk in darkness,
we lie,
and do not the truth:
But if we walk in the light,
as he is in the light,
we have fellowship one with another,
and the blood of Jesus Christ his Son cleanseth us from all sin.

In particular, he is talking about that nature He has, the nature that supplied what we needed to be born again. "In him was life; and the life was the light of men." That is the same John, the Gospel of John. It is all coming out of his mind.

If we walk in the light as He is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus Christ His Son cleanses us from all sin. But if we say we have no sin without walking in that light, particularly without being born again, then His truth is not in us.

I used to wonder why John fought so hard for this, especially when he says in the second chapter:

He that saith he is in the light,
and hateth his brother,
is in darkness even until now.

The primary dividing line, eventually, for whether a man had been born again was this: John says he walks in the light of that nature Jesus gave him. The blood cleanses him from sin, he has fellowship with his brother, and instead of gravitating toward the sin nature, he continues to love his brother and grows stronger and stronger. The dividing line John used was your love for each other.

John Fought a Different Enemy Than Paul Fought

One reason John began to teach like this is because of what had begun to invade the church. The churches he was probably writing to when he said "the elect lady" were the churches in and around Ephesus, where John spent his last days.

In fact, when he was about a hundred years old, he was on the Isle of Patmos, a Turkish penal colony, breaking up rocks. He outlived Domitian the emperor and came back, and he still ministered around the churches in Asia Minor, particularly in that area. I believe he was writing either to a pastor or to sister churches, but either way, the time period matters. He was still saying the same things. He had engaged something that was going on at that time, and he was turning it back and setting doctrine.

Paul was called to the Gentiles. He probably was about the only one, after a while, who believed they could be saved. Peter had to have a visitation. Paul, meanwhile, loved to minister to the Jew, and every time he did, he got in trouble.

He sat at the feet of Gamaliel. The law he once defended, the law he used when putting Christians to death, he now used to defend them and prove that Christ was indeed the very Christ. You would hate to be a Pharisee in a synagogue Paul came into and challenged. They would end up beating him and throwing him out of town, because he could hammer you to death with the law.

Paul did a good job with Judaism. And not only Judaism, but when born-again Jews kept trying to add more and more law to the believer, saying they were perfected by keeping the law after they were born again, some of Paul's first great fights were like Hebrews.

Somebody says, "I do not think Paul wrote that book."

Well, I do. I do not know anybody who had that much knowledge concerning the law except Paul. In Hebrews, Paul took the stance of defending the Hebrew believer against those who were trying to turn them away from Christ. He defended them with Judaism itself.

But John had another enemy in the camp, especially near the end of his life. This is why he says things like this in chapter 4:

Beloved, believe not every spirit,
but try the spirits whether they are of God:
because many false prophets are gone out into the world.
Hereby know ye the Spirit of God:
Every spirit that confesseth that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is of God:
And every spirit that confesseth not that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is not of God:
and this is that spirit of antichrist,
whereof ye have heard that it should come;
and even now already is it in the world.

The Sin Not Unto Death Can Be Met by Intercession

As we close the fifth chapter, I love verse 15:

And if we know that he hear us,
whatsoever we ask,
we know that we have the petitions that we desired of him.

Of course, the petition he addresses in verse 16 is one concerning a brother who went into a certain kind of sin. He said all unrighteousness is sin, and that is the kind most believers are familiar with: you are trying to do good, but there is still sin in your life.

He says:

If any man see his brother sin a sin which is not unto death,
he shall ask,
and he shall give him life for them that sin not unto death.
There is a sin unto death:
I do not say that he shall pray for it.

We covered this last week. God will give the man doing the intercession life for those who sin not unto death. Then John goes on:

All unrighteousness is sin:
and there is a sin not unto death.

When Paul defended the Hebrew believers against the elders, Pharisees, and Hebrew scholars, those men would come in and thunder and rail at some little Hebrew believer who was still on milk. As long as those believers stayed on milk, they ran the danger of denouncing Christ, counting the blood of the covenant unholy, treading underfoot the blood of Jesus Christ, and doing despite to grace.

So Paul, as a champion, defended the little Hebrew believer. That is what Hebrews is about: every shadow getting fulfilled. It is an incredible book.

When it says there is a sin unto death, you may think, "Is it the unpardonable sin? Is it the unforgivable sin?" Most of you are probably not capable of committing it. When they can see your fingernail marks dragged down an entire dam while you are saying, "God, I do not want to fall away," you are not falling away in that sense.

Do you know how many people I have dealt with who thought they had committed the unpardonable sin because circumstances and sins beat them to death and they just gave up? It was not that they did not love God. They just could not hold on, and they thought they had committed the unpardonable sin because they had known Him so well.

I tell them, "You probably would not even have been able to commit it."

The unpardonable sin has everything to do with dismissing Christ as the only way to the Father and accepting another form of salvation.

The Sin Unto Death Was the Doctrine That Removed Christ From the Foundation

When John says, "There is a sin unto death; I do not say that he shall pray for it," this sin unto death, first of all, was connected to these men coming in and preaching.

It was not about casting out devils the way they taught us on milk: "Did Jesus come in the flesh, you filthy devil?" The devil says yes, and then what do you do with him?

John was not talking about the devil. He was talking about the doctrines these men were bringing into the early church in the first, second, third, and fourth centuries. That is the kind of war John was engaged in. That is why he mentions it so many times.

Those who came in refusing to confess that Jesus Christ came in the flesh were antichrist. That was the spirit in the world. They were beginning to commit the sin unto death because they were turning themselves over to it and turning anybody over to it who would follow them.

Paul dealt with the Jew. John dealt with this kind of invasion.

Go to Second John, beginning with verse 1:

The elder unto the elect lady and her children,
whom I love in the truth;
and not I only,
but also all they that have known the truth;
For the truth's sake,
which dwelleth in us,
and shall be with us for ever.
Grace be with you,
mercy, and peace,
from God the Father,
and from the Lord Jesus Christ,
the Son of the Father,
in truth and love.

He says:

I rejoiced greatly that I found of thy children walking in truth,
as we have received a commandment from the Father.
And now I beseech thee, lady,
not as though I wrote a new commandment unto thee,
but that which we had from the beginning,
that we love one another.
And this is love,
that we walk after his commandments.
This is the commandment,
That, as ye have heard from the beginning,
ye should walk in it.

Then here he goes again:

For many deceivers are entered into the world,
who confess not that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh.
This is a deceiver and an antichrist.
Look to yourselves,
that we lose not those things which we have wrought,
but that we receive a full reward.
Whosoever transgresseth,
and abideth not in the doctrine of Christ,
hath not God.
He that abideth in the doctrine of Christ,
he hath both the Father and the Son.
If there come any unto you,
and bring not this doctrine,
receive him not into your house,
neither bid him God speed:
For he that biddeth him God speed
is partaker of his evil deeds.

Notice verse 7 again, re-quoting from First John. Many deceivers have entered into the world who do not confess that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh.

John was about a hundred. He had taken care of Mary. Jesus said, "Woman, behold thy son." What did the commandment say? Honor your father and mother, and what will happen to you? No wonder John lived so long. He took Mary as his own mother into his house, and she lived out her days. It is incredible.

Now time has passed, and he says many deceivers have come into the world.

The problem he has been explaining is connected to the new nature. If you are walking in the light as He is in the light, then we have fellowship one with another. But if you are walking in darkness and claiming you are light, you are deceiving yourself and you are a liar.

For those who took Jesus out of the equation and preached that He is not the way to God and did not come in the flesh, they have no new nature. Which way do you think they are going to gravitate? When that death nature gets loose, that is what it produces. It is not the love John was talking about. They are void of the new nature and void of Christ.

That is what John was fighting so hard to turn back. Many deceivers had come, and many preached that He did not come in the flesh. Look at the outcome two thousand years later. That kind of thing was entering into the church.

John says there is a sin unto death, and he does not say to pray for that. That is why he was so taken to the defense of the elect lady: if they do not come with this doctrine, do not even bid them Godspeed, because you are a partaker of their evil deeds.

Judgment Can Be Mercy When It Stops a Destructive Course

To me, it seemed against God's nature not to pray for somebody. Then He taught me about judgment, and in God's judgment I was able to understand more.

Generally, when God judged somebody, it was a great act of mercy. Take the sorcerer Bar-Jesus and Sergius Paulus, the deputy. The sorcerer was Jewish, so Paul stood up to him and said, "Why do you not cease to pervert the right ways of God? You will not see light for a season."

As I have said, I would much rather be Bar-Jesus the sorcerer who got judged by Paul than the one who was left alone and has been in hell for two thousand years.

It is the same with the man who was introducing leaven into the foundation of the church by having his father's wife. He was judged too. Paul said to turn him over to Satan for the destruction of his flesh. For what ultimate purpose? That he would die to himself and repent in the face of death itself, knowing it was a judgment.

After that judgment was done publicly, he was not much good to the devil anymore, so the devil might as well get him out of the way.

So I understood that judgment took a step further. It was actually a great and incredible act of mercy toward the people being judged. These ones John is talking about were excluding Christ from the equation and turning people over to it, while they themselves denied Him. If you

withstood such a man and judged him, and everything came to pass so that he repented in the face of death, would you not rather that happen to you? Is that not an extreme act of mercy?

First Corinthians 3 Shows What Can Be Built on Christ

Let us go over to Corinthians and look at these little sins that you get involved in. Do I know? Oh yes, every single one of them.

If I had that, if I worked that part and knew everything about you, I would probably get on the elevator, go over to the gambling casino, and explain to all the preachers that I was doing it for the good of the kingdom. I would probably get arrested after hitting it every time, but who knows? I would give the money to God, at least for a while.

It does not work like that.

God deals with a person's heart. The only time He will step inside is if you want Him to in your heart, even if there are consequences with it. He will do that when a whole lot is at stake and He needs you to turn from something because you are heading down a path of destruction.

Sometimes He will show me something, but I cannot just stand up there. Most of the time I know when there is a spirit present, especially if he is one of their friends.

Moving on. Let us go to First Corinthians 3, around verse 9:

For we are labourers together with God:
ye are God's husbandry,
ye are God's building.

You are God's what? Building.

Do not think wood and stuff. Think stones. You are God's building.

According to the grace of God which is given unto me,
as a wise masterbuilder,
I have laid the foundation,
and another buildeth thereon.
But let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon.
For other foundation can no man lay than that is laid,
which is Jesus Christ.

In other words, be very careful what kind of construction material you put on the foundation Paul gave you as a master builder.

Now if any man build upon this foundation
gold, silver, precious stones,
wood, hay, stubble;
Every man's work shall be made manifest:
for the day shall declare it,
because it shall be revealed by fire;
and the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is.

That is the refiner's fire. It burns the dross out of the metal, and you end up with pure metal. It burns the dross out of gold and smelts gold.

If you wanted to know what it looked like, it would be filtered through the Word. Paul is already very clear. He says you will be judged according to his gospel, and he knew God had given it to him. That means you will be judged according to what you do with the new nature He gave you.

Paul used the Ten Commandments to demonstrate the new nature that moved inside us. Now we do not have to commit adultery. Under the law, he said, "I would not even have known covetousness, except the law had said, Thou shalt not covet." Why? Because that is the nature they were born with.

But when you were born again, He said, "I will write My laws in your heart and in your mind. I will be your God, and you will be My people." He said our conscience would bear witness, while our thoughts accused or excused one another. That means there is no thought my new nature and conscience accuses that I will excuse, because I have the strength to walk out of it.

So do you.

Paul said we would be judged according to that standard.

Thank God we received the Holy Spirit. But I can tell you, if He did not get to come because somebody doctored Him out of your life, the new nature is still enough, because it dealt with the power of sin to overpower your mind and take you down.

Romans 8 says:

They that are after the flesh do mind the things of the flesh;
but they that are after the Spirit the things of the Spirit.

He is explaining the man who has been born again. They that are after the flesh, meaning those with death natures, think after the things of the flesh. Their mind is brought under ascendancy to the death nature, and they end up sinning even if they do not want to.

But for the born-again man, my mind has now been brought under subjection to the new nature. The devil does not have the power to make me sin, even if I am not filled with the Holy Spirit. But I do have Him. I have the Holy Spirit, therefore He is my teacher. If I do not have faith, He does what is necessary to teach me how to have it. He will never stop.

All things are possible to him that believes. He does not step around you to do the miracle. He brings you up to the occasion.

The Refiner's Fire Burns Failures but Cannot Replace the Foundation

The refiner's fire on that day is going to come sweeping through your lively stone in God's building. You have been placed on the foundation. What did you do? Did you spend your life teaching people the Holy Ghost is not for today? Miracles are not for today?

He even bore your failures. When that fire tries your work, if you have anything left that did not burn, and you are still standing on the foundation of Jesus Christ crucified, he says you will not have a reward, but you yourself shall be saved.

Is that not tremendous?

Some of you look relieved. At least you get in.

Now let us look at this next part. Wait until I get that one book out. The only reason I have not done it is because somebody gave it to me, and the problem is they believed it. It was a horrible book. I would like to get it out just to show you what people are putting on the foundation, but I am not going to at this point. He misquoted this verse coming up.

Verse 14 says:

If any man's work abide which he hath built thereupon,
he shall receive a reward.
If any man's work shall be burned,
he shall suffer loss:
but he himself shall be saved;
yet so as by fire.

Anything Jesus could bear for you in your failures, He did. It is burned up in the last final judgment as you go into glory. Burned up.

Now watch where this stops:

Know ye not that ye are the temple of God,
and that the Spirit of God dwelleth in you?
If any man defile the temple of God,
him shall God destroy;
for the temple of God is holy,
which temple ye are.

I like verse 18:

Let no man deceive himself.

How did that fellow preach it? In the holiness church I was in, the cigarette defiled the temple.

"You mean this cigarette is going to send me to hell?"

You should have heard me perpetuate that gospel in the mills. We would go into the break shack, and some of them would almost leave when I came in. I do not blame them now.

They would say, "You mean this three-inch cigarette is going to send me to hell?"

I said, "Maybe not, but it makes you smell like you have already been there."

They tried to tell me that was the temple he meant. Drinking, smoking, chewing, and going with girls who do. Through assimilation, that is not the subject.

The subject is this: you are God's husbandry. You are God's building. Paul's contribution was an incredible foundation: Jesus Christ crucified. You can build on that, but be careful how you build, because it is going to be tried by fire. Everything that is not of that foundation is going to be burned. But you yourself will be saved as by the refiner's fire, when the incredible mercy of Jesus follows us home and takes up punishment one more time for our failures.

He said, "Know ye not that ye are the temple of God?" He was not talking about you individually. He was talking about the contribution and the part you played. That is why he says if you defile the temple.

This is after all the trash has been burned and these men just barely made it through because they were born again. Then he says if you defile the temple, the word for "defile" is not what you think with tobacco, drinking, smoking, and chewing. It is destroy.

If you destroy the temple, the only way you can destroy it is by destroying the foundation.

That is what John was locked into. Many deceivers had come into the world, preaching that Jesus Christ did not come in the flesh. The sin unto death is when you teach a whole bunch of people that they can be saved and know God without getting on that foundation. You cannot.

Paul says if a man destroys the temple, God will destroy him. That is why, when John was teaching about our judgment, he said if you see a man sin a sin unto death, he does not say to pray for it. If that man is turning a bunch of people over to death because he is taking truth away from them, this is the same one God said He would destroy.

Do Not Bless the Journey That Is Destroying the Foundation

You do not have to worry about the unpardonable sin. You can pray for that man. John clarified it a little. Do not take him into your home and feed him. Do not bid him Godspeed in teaching you this grand new revelation. My foot.

There will never be a day, though, when God does not want to take anything you have and use it to get somebody else into heaven. That is why sometimes judgment will take the final step. If God uses somebody to turn someone like that over, then they can go tell him what is going to go on. But if that man destroys the temple, he will be destroyed himself.

An old friend of ours, and I preached camp meetings with him, had an IQ that scared me. It was off the board. Now he is turning millions of people over to death who might have repented under other circumstances.

Who was he nurtured under? Men we watched growing up, men who persuaded us that God is alive. He sat under all of them.

So what credence does he have now when he turns and says, "It is all wrong"?

"Now we understand you."

"Yes, I did. I graduated from Oral Roberts University."

"Well, he was rather a healing guy, was he not?"

"Yes."

"Does he believe like you do?"

"Well, no, but I have been illuminated. I am a messenger."

What sin usually needs is just somebody to tell it that it is okay.

If God is judging him, let Him. It is his only chance.

Hallelujah.

So how about the unpardonable sin? Like I said, none of you are probably capable. It is a little heavier, and we will get into it in the next service, if God permits. Like Paul said on the subject, "If God permit, we will go on past these things." So that is what I say: if God permits.

Love for the Brethren Remains the Evidence That the Light Has Come

John drew such an accountable line. He says if you are walking in the light, the darkness has passed and the true light has come. If we walk in the light, we will love our brother.

Why? Because those deceivers were pulling people away into darkness, and they were not being born again anymore. Therefore all the violence and all the different things came as the result of it.

But not you.

By this we know that we are born again: we love the brethren. Hallelujah.

And there are other reasons. If you hate everybody all the time, it is not good. It is not a good sign.

Communion Judges Division in the Lord's Body

In communion, when Paul begins to say, "I hear there are divisions among you, and I partly believe it," I am thinking, "Believe it, Paul. Believe it. This is two thousand years later, and you can believe it."

He says there must be divisions so that those who are approved may be made manifest among you. Because there are divisions, there always have to be leaders of the division. That is who was coming forward.

But Paul says, "I will tell you what Jesus told me." He says, "I will tell you even more than that. Because you are not rightly discerning the Lord's body, many of you are weak and sickly, and many sleep."

You are going to die before your time. Disease will move into your body, and there is nothing you can do about it except change. Of course, that is not the only reason people are sick, but in that passage he is talking about not rightly discerning the Lord's body.

We think that means when we take communion, we are not rightly discerning it: "This is the body which is broken for me, and I am supposed to be healed." That happens sometimes. But Paul was talking about division that had come into the church.

His natural body was a type of His spiritual body. When the stripes beat and broke His back and they pierced Him, as your substitute, His natural body was broken so yours would not have to be. When I take communion, I can say, "This is the blood that reunited me with You. I do not have a death nature anymore. And this is Your body, which was broken for me."

If you go to Deuteronomy 25, it says that if there is a matter between men, they take him before a righteous judge, and the judge can sentence him to up to forty stripes. That was for strife.

Jesus went before the righteous Judge, who was God, and He had no guile in His mouth. He was judged in your place and in my place. When I take communion, I can minister the power that His natural body was broken. It was a type of the spiritual body that is broken up by division.

It was not simply because you took communion wrong and said, "I did not rightly discern that this was the stripes I was healed by," and then waited for healing to come on you. It happens sometimes, but Paul was dealing with division in the first part of the chapter.

So do not take this communion wrong. Judge yourself. Make account of it, and you will not be judged and condemned to die of the same thing the world dies of. We do not have to.

Once again, what John was saying comes into play. By this we know that we are of Him: we walk in the light and we love our brother.

You may not always treat him nice, but you love him.

Hallelujah.

Did you have a good time?